

Interview **S.M. KRISHNA**

"The composite dialogue can wait till terror-related issues are settled"

India's External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna spoke exclusively to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA on what happened at Sharm el-Sheikh and other foreign policy issues. Excerpts:

Q. Your government is being accused of capitulating to Pakistan at the talks at Sharm el-Sheikh.

A. We have not capitulated. India is too big and mature a country for these situations.

Q. What was the reasoning behind India's approach?

A. India's approach is that we can never afford to take a position where we refuse to talk to a nation. Our immediate reaction after the Mumbai terror strike was that we were suspending the composite dialogue till Pakistan brought to justice those who were the perpetrators of the attacks. That remains our position even today and we have not relented on that stand at Sharm el-Sheikh. Pakistan's Prime Minister Yousaf Raza Gilani had assured our prime minister that they were very serious in going after those responsible for Mumbai 26/11. This assurance prompted the issuance of the joint statement.

Q. Why did you delink the composite dialogue from the terror issue?

A. While we may have delinked the composite dialogue from terror, we continued to impress on Pakistan the need to take steps on terror. We told them that there could be no repetition of the kind of terror attack. It was also impressed on Gilani that the terror in-

"We have neither changed our stand nor capitulated to Pakistan. India is too mature a country for these situations."

strumentality that had been created in Pakistan has to be destroyed. We told them that terror knows no boundary and can manifest itself anywhere; that terror cannot be fought on a selective basis but across the board; that we are looking forward to more decisive steps to fight terror because it is in Pakistan's own interest that they do so. We have asked Pakistan to show the same kind of commitment to fighting militants targeting India as they have done in fighting terror in the Swat region. As has been reiterated by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in Parliament, we stick to our stand that the

composite dialogue can wait till the terror-related issues are settled.

Q. But the prime minister had told the Pakistan President that his mandate for talks was limited to how Pakistan handled terror. So what changed in the interim?

A. We wanted to give Pakistan a chance to prove or disprove that they are in control of the machinery in Pakistan. Here is an opportunity for Pakistan to prove they are in total control; that they are going after the terrorists. There are a chain of events that have happened subsequently. After we came back, I think, certain steps have been initiated by Pakistan in terms of follow-up action they propose to take. They have arrested five people responsible for the Mumbai attacks and have filed chargesheets against them and their trial is to start soon in Pakistan. We also received a dossier from them which we are studying. Now there is Mohammed Aijmal Kasab's confession. So we are going stage by stage. Let's wait and watch on how things unfold.

Q. There are experts who believe it is futile to talk to Pakistan. So why talk to Pakistan at all?

A. Because they are our neighbour and we have out-

standing issues with them. We have to make an effort to resolve these issues as neighbours. So we will have to continue to talk to Pakistan. There is no alternative. We have to keep them engaged so that we know what they are planning and what they are up

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to. If you want to focus on development of India, we need to have peace on our borders. It is in India's national interest.

Q. The joint statement also mentions Pakistan's concerns about India's alleged involvement in Balochistan. Why was it included?